

Performing the Subcultural Freak: Leigh Bowery's Peculiar Narcissism and the Disruption of Normativity

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1. *Taboo* (written by Mark Davies Markham and musically arranged by Boy George, Kevan Frost, John Themis and Richie Stevens) premiered at the Venue Theatre in London's West End in 2002 before being transferred to Broadway's Plymouth Theatre in New York the following year.
2. Historically, however, Bowery is not considered part of the New Romantic scene, which functioned roughly during the period 1978–81, but he can be rather viewed as an eminent club figure of the years that followed and were undeniably influenced by it. His club night 'Taboo' (co-hosted with entrepreneur Tony Gordon) ran weekly at Maximus in Leicester Square from 1985–86.
3. *Taboo: The Boy George Musical* (UK: Blackhorse Entertainment, 2004). My own transcription.

The stage musical *Taboo* (2002) narrates the partly fictional story of some of the most prominent figures of the subcultural club scene that flourished in London in the early 1980s and became known as the New Romantics.¹ Leigh Bowery, who is mostly remembered as an extravagant club persona and experimental costume designer, is among those portrayed in the play; hence, its title is a tribute to his legendary club night 'Taboo'.² Perhaps his most acclaimed collaboration, both as a costume designer and performer, is that with the Michael Clark dance company, which lasted for approximately ten years. With only a few exceptions, such as his living installation at the prestigious Anthony d'Offay Gallery that is discussed in this article, Bowery's contribution as a solo performance artist is mainly restricted to shows in night-clubs and other non-institutional spaces. Incarnated by Boy George, the character of Bowery in *Taboo* makes an ostentatious entrance on stage: dressed in a costume that almost perfectly resembles one of Bowery's most distinctive looks, the often called 'spot look' (the characteristic of which is an oversized orange polka dot pattern that expands from the fabric onto his heavily made-up face and hands), he emerges vehemently from what supposedly is a toilet cubicle (perhaps a hint at Bowery's adventurous cottaging habit) and rhetorically addresses the audience with pride: 'Mirror mirror on the wall, who's the biggest freak of all?'³

The term 'freak', once used as 'a badge of shame' to broadly describe individuals with a visible disability, unusual appearance, or mental and behavioural anomaly (and which was thoroughly associated with the cultural institution of the circus during the nineteenth century in the West) has turned into 'an honorific title by the kind of physiologically

4. Leslie Fiedler, *Freaks: Myths and Images of the Secret Self* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1978), 13, 14.
5. *Ibid.*, 300.
6. Elizabeth Grosz, 'Intolerable Ambiguity: Freaks as/ at the Limit' in *Freakery: Cultural Spectacles of the Extraordinary Body*, ed. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson (New York: New York University Press, 1996), 55–66 (56).
7. Robert Bogdan, *Freak Show: Presenting Human Oddities for Amusement and Profit* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1988), 2.
8. The term 'New Romantics' is used loosely in the article to refer to the rather small and exclusive club scene in London that kickstarted in 1978 with 'Bowie Nights' (organized by Steve Strange and Rusty Egan) at Billy's club in Soho, and not to the pop phenomenon of the years that followed.

normal but dissident young people', Leslie Fiedler writes.⁴ This shift in meaning occurred with the anti-establishment counterculture of the 1960s in the West and as cultural revolutions often tend to have an impact on language and expression, 'freak' turned into a positive slang catchword.⁵ Although the so-called 'Freak scene' of the 1960s has long passed and an array of subcultural movements with their distinctive aesthetics, lifestyles, and politics have come to inspire young people throughout the decades, the meaning of 'freak' has since switched to mainly describe the visually strange, the divergent from the 'norm', the (sub)cultural other. Used in a positive or negative manner, 'freak', according to Elizabeth Grosz, has become synonymous with 'a certain social marginalization' and a characteristic of a 'unique social position'; the freak as a culturally constructed subjectivity 'is a being who is considered simultaneously and compulsively fascinating and repulsive, enticing and sickening'.⁶ Similarly, Robert Bogdan, who has written extensively about the cultural history and politics of freak shows, remarks on the ambiguity of the term, which 'has become a metaphor for estrangement, alienation, marginality, the dark side of the human experience'.⁷

Framing Bowery's performed freakery as an aftereffect of the New Romantics, this article examines his series of performances at Anthony d'Offay's gallery as postmodernist manifestations of the traditional figure of the circus freak, and engages with key disability debates to argue for the effectiveness of narcissistic desire as a strategy for challenging the reiteration of norms, disability identities, and ableism through performance art. Although Bowery drew inspiration from a broad spectrum of visual culture, the scope of this article is limited to the vibrant scene and ethos of the New Romantics, which motivated him to relocate to London from Australia in 1980 to initially become a fashion designer and had a significant impact on his art and life.

Delving into the ostentatious style of the New Romantics, the first part of the article considers the ways in which their aesthetics shaped Bowery's identity as an artist, and distinguishes his deep investment in freakery and extreme body manipulation from the mere performance of subcultural subjectivity.⁸ The second part provides a close reading of Bowery's solo shows at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery in line with the politics and cultural history of freak shows, in which so-called human curiosities were exhibited for profit. The conceptual affinity to freak shows demonstrates how as a self-made oddity, Bowery illustrates the constructiveness and artificiality of freak regardless of visible disability. Drawing on the Disability Arts Movement, the final part of the article mounts a critique on Bowery's passive enfreakment and discusses the impact of his peculiar narcissism as an alternative strategy for exposing the oppressive mechanisms of normativity through the surfacing of desire. His performed egomania, eccentric visual language, and fascination with reforming the body can, still, be viewed as agents for challenging his HIV-positive status and as a backlash to the prevailing figure of the sick and disabled body.

Leigh Bowery's Enfreakment as an Aftereffect of the New Romantics

Experimenting with vintage fashion and theatrical make-up and inspired by the pre-punk glittering androgynous glam aesthetic, the New Romantic freaks constituted a threshold for Bowery's extraordinary performative costuming⁹ and artistic development. Their imaginative approach to styling, as well as the audacious exhibitionism of their crafted personas in clubs, were impetus for the progression of Bowery's practice to increasingly higher levels of freakery, although his costuming, which was primarily approached as a form of contemporary art rather than as an imaginative fashion mélange, clearly surpassed any New Romantic's creative feat.

The New Look that defined the scene and transformed King's Road in the early 1980s to 'the longest catwalk in the world' appropriated style ideas from the whole history of fashion (with a strong preference in elements associated with seventeenth and eighteenth-century dress) and favoured second-hand garments from charity shops.¹⁰ Vivienne Westwood's and Malcolm McLaren's boutique, which at the time was called 'Worlds End', embraced the new ethos and style that had originated in nightclubs before breaking it into the mainstream with their first catwalk show 'Pirate Collection' in 1981. Simon Reynolds describes the typical self-fashioning of the club freaks as promoting, however being not limited to

a blend of futuristic and retro elements that jumbled bolero hats, gold braid, toy-soldier coats, Russian cummerbunds, geometric haircuts and pill-box hats, along with stylized make-up that turned the face into an abstract canvas.¹¹

Graham Stewart, likewise, focuses on the New Romantics' allure for make-up:

Exemplifying the gender-bending trend, both sexes slapped on unsubtle quantities of make-up, the definitive look involving geisha-white foundation to create a facial blank canvas on to which dramatic expressions – a raised eyebrow, a frown – or a beauty spot or a circle of rouge could be painted.¹²

The postmodernist approach of the early club freaks to styling, which reflects splendidly the concept of subcultural bricolage,¹³ as well as their narcissistic self-display and gender-bending were decisive for Bowery's gaudy practice. The aggregation of visually conflicting elements and, at times, the fusion of impossible futuristic forms with vintage details in Bowery's work, in addition to his creative approach to make-up and the skin as canvas are manifest in most – if not all – of his early performative looks.

9. I refer to Bowery's costuming as 'performative' to highlight the fact that his garments were not merely body-objects but were instrumental for the performance itself. Just being in them was almost always a performance, while often they were designed and adapted to accommodate his performance ideas. Exploring the performativity of costume, Dorita Hannah has argued that costume design can be regarded as both 'active and activating rather than purely mimetic'. See Dorita Hannah, 'Alarming the Heart: Costume as Performative Body-object-event', *Scene*, 2, no.1 & 2 (2014), 15–34 (18).

10. Colin McFarlane in Carlos Pasini, *Posers – The New Romantics* (London: ABT Productions, 1981).

11. Simon Reynolds, *Rip it Up and Start Again: Postpunk 1978–1984* (London: Faber and Faber Limited, 2005), 326.

12. Graham Stewart, *Bang! A History of Britain in the 1980s* (London: Atlantic Books, 2013), 284.

13. See Dick Hebdige, *Subculture: The Meaning of Style* (London: Routledge, 1997), 102–6.

14. See Roger Malbert, *Carnavalesque* (London: Hayward Gallery Publishing, 2000), 74–97.
15. See David Hevey, *The Creatures Time Forgot: Photography and Disability Imagery* (London: Routledge, 1992), 53–74.
16. Malbert, *Carnavalesque*, 94.
17. Ibid.
18. Michael Bracewell, 'Leigh Bowery's Immaculate Conception' in *The Space Between: Selected Writings on Art*, ed. Doro Globus (London: Ridinghouse, 2012), 126–33 (129–30).
19. Bowery created *Minty* in 1993 with Richard Torry and included Nicola Bateman and Matthew Glamorre.
20. Ibid., 130.

The non-mainstream dramatic presentation of self that the post-punk club freaks employed and Bowery took to extremes echoes the long tradition of the carnival, the ethos and imagery of which often correlate with practices of performance art.¹⁴ To refer to the creative process of fashioning a subcultural subjectivity through the dissonant presentation of self I borrow the term 'enfreakment' from David Hevey who used it first in disability discourse to argue that it is the mechanism of representation that renders the strange appearance freakish and not the form of the body itself.¹⁵ Writing about the grotesque in contemporary art, Roger Malbert points out that 'extremes of decoration [...] are perceived as denaturing the body, reducing it to a playground for shallow effects: at best, frivolous, at worst, blasphemous'.¹⁶ For the members of spectacular subcultures like the New Romantics, as well as for Bowery, it is the embodiment of visual cacophony, one that becomes manifest through their incongruous dress codes and negates mainstream sensibilities of style that, I maintain, fuels their enfreakment and renders them cultural aliens. For the 'fashion-conscious young, the body often becomes a site of contestation', likewise, for Bowery and his milieu, the enfreakment of self turns into their main strategy for disrupting bourgeois standards and judgment.¹⁷ However, in contrast to his clubbing contemporaries, Bowery challenged the idea of fashion significantly and blurred the boundaries between costuming, art, and performance. His avant-garde designs and styling surpass any imaginative attempt for sartorial innovation; 'grotesque' or 'disarmingly pretty', his ideas, as Michael Bracewell observes, 'never correspond to any orthodoxy already apparent in pop, fashion or art'.¹⁸ His short-lived band *Minty*, for example, (in the gigs of which Bowery famously 'gave birth' on stage to Nicola Bateman who was hidden underneath his costume) is an ambitious mishmash act of electronic music, extravagant costuming, and theatrical performance.¹⁹

Unlike the members of subcultures like the New Romantics, Bowery does not simply occupy the position of the freak metaphorically due to his eccentric performances, outrageous looks, and subcultural status 'as an underground social celebrity', to use Bracewell's words.²⁰ It is through his art and performances that he engages with the freakish and monstrous aesthetic fully by manipulating and visually distorting his body beyond accepted norms, appropriating the grotesque and uncanny appearance of circus freaks often. Beyond the extremely padded costumes, layers of make-up, and body paint that gave him a monstrous figure, Bowery experimented with human flesh and the way it can be changed. By manipulating the fat of his corpulent body and accentuating specific areas – especially those that are considered unflattering in mainstream fashion when bulging, such as the abdomen – or by creating the illusion of femaleness and concealing his genitals convincingly, Bowery performs bizarreness by unsettling prevailing body ideals and cisgender expectations for bodily display. Like many contemporary artists, including Bowery, who use their bodies to challenge stereotypical notions of beauty and concepts of gender and

21. Andrea Stulman Dennett, 'The Dime Museum Freak Show Reconfigured as Talk Show' in *Freakery: Cultural Spectacles of the Extraordinary Body*, ed. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson (New York: New York University Press, 1996), 315–26 (320).
22. Fiedler, *Freaks*, 33.
23. Grosz, 57, emphasis in original.
24. Analola Santana, *Freak Performances: Dissidence in Latin American Theater* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2018), 11.
25. Rosemary Garland-Thomson, 'Introduction: From Wonder to Error – A Genealogy of Freak Discourse in Modernity' in *Freakery: Cultural Spectacles of the Extraordinary Body*, ed. by Rosemarie Garland-Thomson (New York: New York University Press, 1996), 1–19 (3).
26. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson, *Extraordinary Bodies: Figuring Physical Disability in American Culture and Literature* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1997), 68.
27. Michael M. Chemers, *Staging Stigma: A Critical Examination of the American Freak Show* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2008).
28. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson, *Staring: How We Look* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2009), 32.
29. Silvia Rief, *Club Cultures: Boundaries, Identities, and Otherness* (New York and Oxford: Routledge, 2009), 9.

sex, some circus freaks 'suggested ambiguous types of sexuality' and excited the imagination of 'a sexually repressed audience', Andrea Stulman Dennett remarks.²¹ Bowery's unique queer visual language, which can be translated as in a constant state of flux, is undeniably a key aspect of his work. He often turns into a self-fashioned hermaphrodite: 'the most grotesque of all side show Freaks'.²² By blending the human and the alien, the natural and the artificial, the familiar and the uncanny, Bowery frustrates commonly perceived binaries with splendour. The freak, similarly, is, according to Grosz, 'an *ambiguous* being whose existence imperils categories and oppositions dominant in social life'.²³ Notably, even though the figure of the circus freak is inextricably linked in popular imagination to disability and the unusually formed body, as Analola Santana remarks, in accentuating difference it also stigmatized certain ethnic and racial identities that were often exhibited as 'exotic' others solidifying colonial imperialist stereotypes of western superiority.²⁴

In the same way that monstrous bodies challenged 'the order of things' during ancient times and 'appeared as sublime, merging the terrible with the wonderful, equalizing repulsion with attraction',²⁵ Bowery's appropriation of a monstrous and, at the same time, glamorous aesthetic questioned the widely accepted codes of fashion and propriety, and helped him craft and establish a unique subversive subjectivity. Although during the heyday of freak shows in the nineteenth century the extraordinary body of the freak provided reassurance to the 'normal' able-bodied person, for disabled subjects, in particular, it represented 'a potential for individual freedom denied by cultural pressures toward standardization'.²⁶ For Michael Chemers, the performance of freakery at the circus became throughout the years a significant political and aesthetic vehicle for disabled performers to manage their stigma and to constantly negotiate their social position.²⁷ Likewise, Bowery's desire to shock and deride bourgeois taste by enacting the freak is rooted not only in his repulsion towards the monotony and unrealistic perfectionism of the fashion industry but in a general dissatisfaction with normative cultural values. By deliberately becoming what Garland-Thomson terms a 'stareable sight', that is a person whose unusual appearance attracts attention, Bowery as well as the less spectacular New Romantic freaks that laid the groundwork for his monumental crafted personas violate the 'rules' of mainstream culture and social convention that 'strictly' regulate 'our behaviour, appearance, and our relations'.²⁸

The club, which is viewed as the key component behind the existence of New Romantics, cultivated and sustained to a great extent the process of enfreakment by becoming a catalyst for the creative stylization of self that the members of the scene employed. As a space flaunting 'carnival-esque features' where, according to Silvia Rief, 'insincere, playful identifications can be expressed and lived',²⁹ the club provided a safe environment for New Romantics to experiment and act out their self-fashioned characters. It comes as no surprise, therefore, that Bowery not only hosted his own club night 'Taboo' but utilized club spaces in

general as the main outlet for his subversive performative practice, transforming the act of being a freak to an art form.

Straight from the Nightclub: Leigh Bowery's Living Installation at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery and the Freak-garde

Bowery's performances at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery in October 1988 in Central London was his first and only solo show to take place in an art institutional space. Malbert, who views Bowery as 'the most famous exponent of transgressive masquerade' in London's club scene at the time, aligns his 'grotesquely exaggerated looks' and living installation with the cultural figure of the 'freak in a fairground side-show'.³⁰ Although Bowery's performance, which is examined below in detail, does not explicitly reproduce the cultural and aesthetic specificities of the traditional freak show, it restages, I maintain, its politics and sociological extensions resonating with Robin Blyn's concept of the 'freak-garde', namely a distinctive avant-garde tradition in the arts of the twentieth century that drew inspiration from the freak show to produce and promote distinctive modes of being.³¹ As a norm-breaker, Bowery signifies the embodiment of a proud 'true freak', which, in accordance with Fiedler, 'challenges the conventional boundaries between male and female, sexed and sexless, animal and human, large and small, self and other, and consequently between reality and illusion, experience and fantasy, fact and myth'.³²

The freak show, the politics of which, unintentionally perhaps, Bowery appropriated in his performances at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery, is defined by Bogdan as 'the formally organized exhibition for amusement and profit of people with physical, mental, or behavioral anomalies, both alleged and real'.³³ This kind of popular entertainment was 'limited to a class with poor taste' as Bogdan puts it, and had its golden era from around 1840 through 1940, mostly in the United States, where dime museums, circuses, fairs, amusement parks, and carnivals, often hosted freak shows.³⁴ Stulman Dennett describes freak shows as a place where bizarreness and irregularity were accentuated through special costumes, narratives, and stylized presentations to appeal to a paying audience. The display of extraordinary bodies as such determined the freakish and shaped perceptions of normality through 'the public examination of what are essentially private affairs'.³⁵ Similarly, Garland-Thomson views freak shows as 'public ritual[s]' where visitors were engaged 'in the collective act of looking': human curiosities sparked the spectators' imagination, ratified uniformity, and, occasionally, reinforced national identity.³⁶

For 5-days Bowery exhibited himself at Anthony d'Offay's gallery for two hours daily in a different outfit each day (except from the last day in which the performance lasted for four hours and included two outfits).³⁷ The installation involved a seemingly basic set that included only

30. Malbert, *Carnavalesque*, 90, 94.
31. Robin Blyn, *The Freak-Garde: Extraordinary Bodies and Revolutionary Art in America* (Minneapolis and London: University of Minnesota Press, 2013), xix. John Vaccaro's theatrical ensemble 'Play-House of the Ridiculous' is exemplary of the 1960s experimental queer theatre scene in New York which appropriated freakery and suggested an aesthetic and conceptual affinity with the traditional fairground amusements of the past. See Giulia Palladini, *The Scene of Foreplay: Theater, Labor, and Leisure in 1960s New York* (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 2017).
32. Fiedler, *Freaks*, 24.
33. Bogdan, *Freak Show*, 2.
34. Ibid.
35. Stulman Dennett, 'The Dime Museum Freak Show Reconfigured as Talk Show', 325.
36. Garland-Thomson, 'Introduction', 4.
37. Nicola Bateman, Unpublished Interview with the Author, Eastbourne, October 2018.

a chaise-longue in the middle of the gallery space, which had been transformed such that a two-way mirror separated Bowery (on the chaise-longue), and the audience. The lighting design, which was set to illuminate Bowery's space while the observers were in relative darkness, allowed him only to be able to see his own reflection on the glass. In addition, the sound of traffic was transmitted from the gallery's speakers and the attendants' sense of smell was stimulated by a different scent each day: for example, 'one day banana the next marshmallow'.³⁸

In terms of action, the performance was quite static, resembling the stylistic attributes of tableaux vivants; a fact that undoubtedly was made up for by Bowery's grandiose presence. Cerith Wyn Evans' short documentary film of the daily performances gives a glimpse of Bowery's apparently narcissistic desire. He is shown attired in six of his most iconic looks spending most of the time observing his own reflection.³⁹ Produced with basic means and minimal editing, the film (which opens with Bowery in his signature 'spot' look) is focused entirely on Bowery and neglects the overall conditions and the audience without providing as a result a complete narrative and a thorough account of the event. This filmmaking approach can be viewed, perhaps, as a consequence of Bowery's captivating presence that overshadows the surrounding circumstances or as an accentuation of his performed egomania.

During the impromptu performances, Bowery would rest stretched out on the chaise-longue checking himself in the mirror, striking odd poses and moving around from time to time. When he is not posing gracefully, grimacing, adjusting his outfit, or playing sensually with his tongue he just lies on the chaise-longue in a meditative state reminiscent of Manet's *Olympia* (1863) in a queer interpretation. There is a sense of dramatic calmness in Bowery's shots as he abides in darkness under a spotlight all dressed up. The viewer's gaze is unavoidably fixed upon his arresting outfits and the freakish styling as he enacts a disparate fashion mannequin of sorts posing for an invisible photographer. Fashion practices and art converge in a distorted way in Bowery's performance. However, in opposition, for instance, to the sleek tableaux performances of Vanessa Beecroft, which, according to Sally O'Reilly, offer 'a novel view of idealized beauty' and exist in the intersection of fashion, beauty industries and the art market,⁴⁰ Bowery's glorifies sub-cultural freakishness and complicates both the stereotypical notion of haute couture elegance as well as the grandeur of institutional art.

By disturbing the visual status quo with his 'Baroque beauty',⁴¹ Bowery demands to be stared at and offers interminable voyeurism to the astonished spectators. Unlike Wyn Evans' footage that is obsessively focused on Bowery, Dick Jewell's film *What's Your Reaction to the Show?* deals only with the impressions that Bowery's performance left in the attendants and reveals their mixed responses.⁴² The film, which was shot during all 5 days of the exhibition, includes clips of Bowery's performances along with statements of members of the audience that were confronted with the question 'What's your reaction to the show?' upon exiting the gallery. The film reveals a variety of responses from

38. Sue Tilley, *Leigh Bowery: The Life and Times of an Icon* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1997), 217.

39. See Cerith Wyn Evans, *Leigh Bowery at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery, 1988* (London: Anthony d'Offay Gallery, 1988).

40. Sally O'Reilly, *The Body in Contemporary Art* (London: Thames and Hudson, 2009), 42–3.

41. Garland-Thomson used the term 'Baroque beauty' to describe the 'irregular, exaggerated and peculiar'. See Garland-Thomson, *Staring*, 189.

42. See Dick Jewell, *Leigh Bowery – What's Your Reaction to the Show?* (London, 1988).

43. Bateman,
Unpublished
Interview with the
Author.

44. Bogdan, 8. The clear distinction between born and fake freaks can be viewed as an effect of the growing need that emerged in the mid-nineteenth century for scientifically identifying, classifying, and defining bodies, which shaped what Ellen Samuels calls 'the age of bio-certification', that is the contemporary inflexible process of validating an individual's disability through medical standards and bureaucracy. See Ellen Samuels, *Fantasies of Identification: Disability, Gender, Race* (New York and London: New York University Press, 2014).

45. Bogdan, *Freak Show*, 234–66.

46. Amelia Klem Osterud, *The Tattooed Lady: A History* (Golden: Speck Press, 2009), 52.

47. *Ibid.*, 53.

48. Garland-Thomson, 'Introduction', 10.

a particularly mixed crowd that included Bowery's friends, nightclub enthusiasts, fashionistas, art fans, and people who accidentally, perhaps, came across the show. Beyond the most predictable responses, which range from the show being just 'interesting', 'fantastic', or 'extraordinary' to 'boring', 'static', and 'crap', there were some insightful and engaging comments that associate Bowery's performances with tableaux vivants or the 'living sculptures' of Gilbert and George, whose work Bowery admired (although, Bateman recalls, 'he didn't like to admit to any influences'⁴³). Furthermore, the feeling of attending a peep show or watching a strange animal at the zoo that some mentioned, correlates with the voyeuristic gaze that the confined circus freak induced to spectators and, therefore, validates Bowery's performances as manifestations of the freak-garde. The affinity between his performances at Anthony d'Offay's gallery and those of the traditional circus freak can hardly be ignored.

Viewed in the context of freak shows, Bowery's artifice suggests the embodiment of the self-made monstrous persona. The main categories of human curiosities that were exhibited were not limited to 'born freaks', namely people with visible 'real physical anomalies' usually due to a medical condition, but also included 'made freaks' who, like Bowery, 'do something to themselves that make them unusual enough for exhibit', as well as 'novelty acts', which refer to 'an unusual performance or ability'.⁴⁴ Circassian beauties ('Middle Eastern-style' women with 'frizzled, bushy, dark hair' supposedly originating from the Caucasus region), heavily tattooed people, and fabricated 'wild' men and women are some of the most typical examples of 'self-made' exhibits who acquired their freakishness for the purpose of the show, while the broader category of novelty performers included the likes of fire eaters, sword swallowers, snake charmers, anatomical wonders, and contortionists.⁴⁵

In addition, fictional biographical narratives sparked the audience's imagination and appropriate costuming emphasized the bizarreness of the freak; both were essential elements in the process of enfreakment. Tracing the social history of the densely tattooed ladies who worked in travelling circuses as exhibits in the United States, Amelia Klem Osterud echoes Bogdan when she remarks that tattooed freaks in particular deployed 'a variation of a standard captivity narrative' to excite the spectators and to confirm, at the same time, their stereotypical ideas about 'primitive' civilizations and indigenous cultures.⁴⁶ The most common stories involved the idea of a helpless Westerner captured by an indigenous tribe in some 'exotic' island and turned into a freak after being forced to endure the painful traditional ritual of tattooing. The fictitious tales that accompanied the lightly clothed tattooed freak turned the 'regular working-class' subject into a 'victim' whose body 'had been brutalized by savages' and carried 'permanent symbols of torture'.⁴⁷

Befittingly, therefore, Garland-Thomson highlights that enfreakment in the context of freak shows 'emerges from cultural rituals that stylize, silence, differentiate, and distance the persons whose bodies the freak-hunters or showmen colonize and commercialize'.⁴⁸ The way human

49. Bogdan, *Freak Show*, 95.

50. Eric Fretz, 'P.T. Barnum's Theatrical Selfhood and the Nineteenth-Century Culture of Exhibition' in *Freakery: Cultural Spectacles of the Extraordinary Body*, ed. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson (New York: New York University Press, 1996), 97–107 (98).

51. Bogdan, *Freak Show*, 104.

52. *Ibid.*, 105, 108.

53. Anthony d' Offay Gallery, *Leigh Bowery* (press release) (1988).

54. Garland-Thomson, *Extraordinary Bodies*, 66.

55. Bogdan, *Freak Show*, 108.

56. Garland-Thomson, *Extraordinary Bodies*, 65.

57. Bracewell, 'Leigh Bowery's Immaculate Conception', 131.

exhibits were promoted, their stylized presentation that included costumes and narratives, and the way they acted, were imperative aspects 'in making a freak', Bogdan notes.⁴⁹ The exhibition of human oddities, like Bowery's performances at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery and his art more broadly, was premised on the construction of dissonant characters and their public performance of freakery. Essentially, freak shows 'displayed theatrical Selfhood to the public', Eric Fretz characteristically writes,⁵⁰ and, I maintain, Bowery did by adopting a sort of aggrandized style of self-presentation.

The two main modes of presentation for circus freaks, namely 'the standardized set of techniques, strategies, and styles that showmen used', were the exotic and the aggrandized.⁵¹ In contrast to the exotic mode – in which non-western persons were exhibited as 'culturally strange', 'primitive', and in most cases inferior to the spectator – the aggrandized mode suggested that, beyond the anomalous body, the freak was a 'high-status person' with exceptional talents of a 'socially prestigious nature'.⁵² Likewise, in the gallery's press release for his performance series, Bowery is praised for his 'extraordinary presence' and 'exceptional talents' and is presented as a 'cultural icon' and 'design phenomenon', and as a celebrity of sorts of 'the alternative and new cultural scene in London'.⁵³ Like Bowery, who often attracted the attention of the media and became a recognizable subcultural figure of London, some circus freaks gained fame, wealth, and popularity outside of the circus business; they were 'celebrities as well as spectacles'.⁵⁴ Moreover, the aggrandized mode required relevant props of eminent taste, which included refined clothes and fancy accessories.⁵⁵ Bowery's performances at Anthony d'Offay's gallery, therefore, can be viewed as a postmodernist version of the traditional aggrandized performances of freaks at the circus. His impressively crafted costumes and phenomenal styling of self, which exceed all modes of mainstream and sub-cultural representations, establish his image in the eyes of the audience as that of nightclub freak royalty.

The freak show's stage arrangement is another element that contributed to the manufacture of freak and bears similarities to Bowery's setting at the gallery. '[B]ounded by the show's forms and conventions, the freak soothes the onlookers' self-doubt by appearing as their antithesis', writes Garland-Thomson; the spectator 'produces and acts, but the onstage freak is idle and passive [...] the freak is looked at and named [...] the freak is fixed, confined by the material structures and the conventions of the staging'.⁵⁶ In Bowery's case, this antithesis and distance from the audience are emphasized by the two-way mirror, which does not only separate the two but shuts out any kind of interaction.

Bracewell notes that as 'extensions of his own ritual of studying himself in the mirror', Bowery's performances at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery were his 'last laugh at the expense of formal art'.⁵⁷ In a downright Duchampian manner, Bowery positioned his freakish-looking persona straight from the nightclub into the gallery as an art object, disrupting the formal conventions of art. Besides, the fact that the

58. Art exhibitions in department store windows (and the relationship of art and consumerism more broadly) were introduced for the first time with Pop Art during the mid-1950s. See Cécile Whiting, *A Taste for Pop: Pop Art, Gender, and Consumer Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998).
59. Jennifer Fisher and Jim Drobnick, *CounterPoses: Re-imagining Tableaux Vivants*, (Montreal, QC: Oboro, 2002), 13.
60. Bogdan, *Freak Show*, 3.
61. Fisher and Drobnick, *CounterPoses*, 6.
62. Ibid.
63. Blyn, *The Freak-Garde*: xix.
64. Petra Kupperts, *Disability and Contemporary Performance: Bodies on Edge* (New York: Routledge, 2003), 31.
65. Jennifer Eisenhauer, 'Just Looking and Staring Back: Challenging Ableism Through Disability Performance Art', *Studies in Art Education*, 49, no. 1 (2007), 7–22 (11).
66. Garland-Thomson, *Staring*, 3.

following month he repeated the performance with a few adjustments in the shop window of Parco⁵⁸ (a department store in Tokyo) complicates further the already problematic notions of authenticity, exclusivity, and the high/low polarity that prevail in art institutions sustaining the art market. In other respects, 'the act of self-objectification', according to Jennifer Fisher and Jim Drobnick, 'is a powerful technique for interrogating and transgressing convention'.⁵⁹ Thus, it is the infiltration of an anticipated high art space with subcultural quirkiness that challenges the conventional apparatus of art and, at the same time, renders a rather marginalized subject an empowering selfhood. By performing the subcultural freak in a gallery, Bowery consolidates in a postmodernist fashion Bogdan's argument about the manufacturing of freak: "Freak" is a frame of mind, a set of practices, a way of thinking about and presenting people. It is [...] the performance of a stylized presentation'.⁶⁰

Counter Modes: Agency and Narcissistic Desire in Negotiating Enfreakment in Performance

Fisher and Drobnick coined the term 'living display' to describe the kind of 'staged presentation', like Bowery's at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery, that involves 'human beings' and stands 'at the intersection of exhibition and event'.⁶¹ Freak shows constitute a precursor form of living displays and have provided the stimuli for performance artists in the twentieth century to actively 'confront such practices' and 'transform cultural attitudes' through their work and their bodies.⁶² This agrees fully with the concept of freak-grade, which 'insists' on 'political change' based on the 'alternatives' of the widely perceived 'repressed and oppressed subject'.⁶³

Writing about disability and contemporary performance, Petra Kupperts notes that the freak show and the medical theatre, where 'disabled people's performances have been historically confined to, [aggregate the freak's] [...] history of oppression'.⁶⁴ Similarly, Jennifer Eisenhauer remarks that either as 'specimen' or 'curiosity', the disabled subject is in both instances vulnerable in front of 'the powerful and dehumanizing stare of the audience'.⁶⁵ Detached from the club, his 'natural' surrounding, and confined within the gallery space, Bowery with his freakish looks turns himself – even momentarily – into a human oddity, a strange sight for the eyes of the 'normal' spectators. It is the power of staring, which Garland-Thomson describes as 'an interrogative gesture'⁶⁶ seeking a narrative, that validates Bowery's freakishness. Cultural alienation, as well as Bowery's self-objectification during the performances, 'depends upon looking as an act of domination':

When persons in a position that grants them authority to stare take up that power, staring functions as a form of domination, marking the staree as

the exotic, outlaw, alien, or other. The colonizing look marks its bearer as legitimate and its object as outsider.⁶⁷

67. Ibid., 42.

In contrast, however, to Bowery's passive enfreakment by turning into the silent object of the stare, certain performance artists within the Disability Arts Movement⁶⁸ 'challenge and disrupt', according to Eisenhauer, 'this problematic process of just looking [...] through a critical appropriation of the stare'.⁶⁹ Unlike Bowery, their deliberate engagement with the historical freak show seeks to actively deconstruct the oppressive mechanism of normative identity formation and the ableist ideologies promoted by such displays, and at the same time confront the spectators' intrusive act of looking. The main strategy for shifting their colonizing stare to a dynamic agency (a decisive quality that Bowery's performance lacks) is the critical appropriation of the historical and cultural apparatuses that stigmatize and marginalize disabled subjects followed by 'autobiography', that is a bold verbal account concerning their unusual bodies.⁷⁰

Garland-Thomson explores the transformative quality allowed by 'the stare-and-tell ritual' in the performances of Mary Duffy, an artist born without arms, who appears nude in front of the audience as an enactment of the classical figure of the *Venus de Milo*: 'the quintessential icon of female beauty'.⁷¹ She describes Duffy's performance as she emerges 'out of the darkness [...], spotlight from the front against a black background [...] forcing the audience to look at her completely naked body'.⁷² Similar to Bowery's alien appearance, her disabled body presented as such evokes fascination, curiosity, bewilderment, and awe, complicating perceived ideas surrounding disability identity and beauty. However, it is when she addresses the audience and turns into a 'speaking subject' that overturns the dynamic of starring and dismantles her objectification, which Duffy 'so commandingly rejects in her performances'.⁷³ In her short monologue, she talks openly about her unusual body and the feelings that stem from the words used (silently or not) to describe her condition. She recalls all the stereotypical questions she frequently encounters and the assumptions people make of her appearance, and dwells on her body being 'whole, complete and functional'.⁷⁴

By exposing her body as a classic icon of female beauty and by appropriating the terms used by others to describe her, Duffy vigorously makes the viewers witnesses of the process of her own enfreakment and, most importantly, criticizes the politics of appearance that renounce distinctive subjects as non-normative. As Garland-Thomson writes:

This autobiographical form unsettles cultural assumptions about humanity, femaleness, disability, and self by invoking and juxtaposing all of these categories. By merging the visual and the narrative, body and word signify together in an act of self-making. Unique to disability, this genre manipulates the stare in order to renarrate disability.⁷⁵

68. Allan Sutherland describes disability arts as an umbrella term that broadly refers to 'art made by disabled people which reflects the experience of disability'. See <http://www.disabilityartsonline.org.uk/what-is-disability-arts> (accessed August 7, 2019).

69. Eisenhauer, 'Just Looking and Staring Back', 12.

70. Ibid., 17–9. In a similar fashion, certain Latin American performances and plays, which Santana examined in relation to 'aesthetics of freakery' and the construction of Latin American bodies 'through a discourse of difference', utilized the allegory of the freak to 'make a political statement about imperialist powers that seek to dominate and deform Latin American identity politics'. See Santana, *Freak Performances*, 19.

71. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson, 'Staring Back: Self-Representations of Disabled Performance Artists', *American Quarterly*, 52, no. 2 (2000), 334–8 (337, 336).

72. Ibid., 336.

73. Ibid., 337, 338.

74. Quoted in Ibid., 337.

75. Ibid., 338.

It is this combination of narrative and the visual display that creates the dynamic exchange of agency between the performer and the audience and permits the stareable subject to stare back. Unlike Bowery's body, which appears at Anthony d'Offay's gallery as a spectacularly manipulated object exclusively to be viewed, the natural body in disability performance, serving as the 'medium' and the 'content' of the performance, becomes 'an object both to be viewed and to be explained'.⁷⁶

In contrast, Bowery's 'theatrical' mannerism and 'extravagant clothing' emit 'an extreme egocentrism' seemingly far removed from critical engagement: 'It was all about him and his body. The audience is secondary' René Zechlin writes.⁷⁷ Similarly, for Martin Engler, the mirror effect that obstructed any kind of dialogue between Bowery and the observers allowed him to 'create an existential, almost iconic image of narcissistic loneliness and self-inflicted isolation'.⁷⁸ His performance, which seemed a natural progression for Bowery who consumed a considerable amount of energy daily posing and studying himself in the plethora of mirrors in his flat,⁷⁹ can potentially be dismissed as mere exhibitionism or a superficial act of vanity. Despite, however, the adverse overtones attached to narcissistic desire (particularly in feminist body art), it can be viewed as a liberatory act of self-expression, according to Amelia Jones.⁸⁰

Jones suggests that as 'the exploration of and fixation on the self', narcissism, which she views as an inseparable aspect of late capitalism, leads to the projection of the subject's 'internal structures of identification and desire outward', having an impact on the other; it can be regarded, therefore, as a strategy not only for permitting one's deepest desires to surface but for communicating and relating one's self to the other.⁸¹ What Jones considers genuinely subversive in regards to the 'fundamentally intersubjective' nature of narcissistic body art is that this kind of work emerged in the late 1960s and early 1970s when the concept of self was becoming increasingly problematic in art discourse.⁸² Its significance, therefore, lies in the fact that body art (and performance art more broadly) can be seen as 'exacerbating the fragmentation of the normative subject of modernism': the white, able-bodied, heterosexual male.⁸³ For Jones, the disclose of the inner self, facilitated by narcissism, can potentially unsettle what Judith Butler calls 'the reiteration of norms', which is understood as the structure that forces the subject to fulfil certain stereotypical standards through particular socially acceptable identifications.⁸⁴ By failing to do so, the subject may open up an array of new possibilities for embodiment that would, otherwise, remain in the margins; in Jones' words: it 'may access the domain of *abject* beings'. She writes:

It is this domain of abject beings that I believe the most interesting body art projects to be enacting: women as (provisional) subjects, men who are openly ambivalent in their relationship to the phallus and particular in spite of their privileged masculinity, subjects who are otherwise not normative.⁸⁵

76. Ibid., 334.

77. René Zechlin, 'Introduction – The Human Body as an Artwork' in *Leigh Bowery: Beautified Provocation*, ed. René Zechlin (Hannover and Heidelberg: Kehrer Verlag, 2008), 31–2 (31).

78. Martin Engler, 'The Multiple Bodies of Leigh Bowery' in *Leigh Bowery: Beautified Provocation*, ed. René Zechlin (Hannover and Heidelberg: Kehrer Verlag, 2008), 55–60 (59).

79. Bateman, Unpublished Interview with the Author.

80. Amelia Jones, *Body Art/Performing the Subject* (Minneapolis, London: University of Minnesota Press, 1998), 46.

81. Ibid., 46, 48.

82. Ibid., 47.

83. Ibid.

84. Ibid., 49.

85. Ibid., 50, emphasis in original.

86. Tobin Siebers, *Disability Theory* (Ann Arbor: The University of Michigan Press, 2008), 37.

87. O'Reilly, 77.

88. Ibid.

89. Ibid., 79.

90. Ibid., 77.

91. Ibid., 79.

92. Heather Warren-Crow, 'Acquired Community: Leigh Bowery and *Hail the New Puritan's* Misc-en-scène of AIDS' in *Different Bodies: Essays on Disability in Film and Television*, ed. Marja Evelyn Mogk (Jefferson: McFarland and Company, 2013), 39–54 (48).

93. Ibid., 41. Some of the most prominent examples in which Bowery's characteristic and 'mobile' 'spotted looks' have appeared are the costumes of Michael Clark's dance company, *i-D* magazine, a 'Get Well Soon sympathy card', photographs by Fergus Greer and his living installation at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery. Posthumously, they have been featured in the musical *Taboo*, while a wallpaper print by De Angelis and Garner bears 'an ellipsoidal dot pattern composed of stylized illustrations of Bowery's face'. See Ibid., 40.

By enacting his inner self queerly attired and by bringing a domestic ritual into the public realm, Bowery at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery can be seen as an abject subject that seized the opportunity to disrupt or complicate the reiteration of norms in multiple levels with his 'irregular' masculinity, 'freakish' appearance, and 'aberrant' attitude. Furthermore, viewed as an expression of pathologized individualism, narcissism, according to the literature on psychology, is often attributed to disability and suffering. Disabled subjects allegedly become self-absorbed, socially withdrawn, and attention seekers. This 'accusation of narcissism', as Tobin Siebers points out, has turned into 'one of the strongest weapons' against disabled individuals.⁸⁶ Accordingly, Bowery's narcissistic desire could perhaps be translated as a refiguring of the potential of the disparaged figure of the narcissist.

According to O'Reilly, normativity is forced on the body through various routes including appropriate manners or beauty ideals and fashion.⁸⁷ As discussed above, the restrictive cultural norms of ableism are disputed in disability performance art by exposing the raw realism of the unusually formed body. However, seizing control of one's appearance, like Bowery does by inscribing his inner desires on his body and letting them surface through his narcissistic impulses, can also be an effective strategy of resistance and visibility; '[c]lothing and the body that wears it', O'Reilly notes, 'are a means of proclaiming and identifying difference or solidarity'.⁸⁸ Apart from being seen as a medium for rejecting the reiteration of norms and affiliating with freakishness, and viewed within a broader context, Bowery's heavily decorated body could be specifically read in relation to the various socio-political circumstances during the 1980s and his personal battle against HIV/AIDS – a form of disability, albeit not always visible.⁸⁹ O'Reilly, thus, views Bowery's costumed body as a backlash to 'Thatcherite conservatism' and as a 'scandalous self-promotional tool' at a time when people with HIV/AIDS 'were expected to fade quietly and apologetically away'.⁹⁰ Although Bowery's disability remained a private matter and became widely known after his death from an AIDS-related illness in 1994, his 'individualistic looks', O'Reilly insists, 'challenged an increasingly market-driven and bureaucratic society, in which AIDS sufferers were often depersonalized, represented as statistics by a medical profession under pressure to fulfil targets'.⁹¹

Heather Warren-Crow notes that 'with its concomitant mental images of dead bodies and quarantined houses', the homophobic term 'gay plague' (as HIV/AIDS was initially labelled since it was believed that it could only spread among male homosexuals) provided reassurance to heteronormative sensibilities by tactically bypassing the fact that most people infected with the virus were not 'stuck at home' but were leading a normal life.⁹² Similarly to O'Reilly, Warren-Crow argues that Bowery's performative costuming is indicative of 'the dissident mobility of queers', and that his signature 'spot' look in particular (his 'most dynamic' and 'mobile' of all) can convey 'an aesthetic of community acquisition' against the attempts to eradicate queer

94. Ibid., 45, 41.

95. Ibid., 42. Similarly, Octavio Campo's dance-theatre piece *The Bugchasers* (2007) challenges prevailing perceptions surrounding individuals with HIV and disabled people more broadly who are confined to the representation of illness and disability. See Patrick McKelvey, 'Choreographing the Chronic' in *Queer Dance: Meanings and Makings*, ed. Clare Croft (New York: Oxford University Press, 2017), 263–79.

96. Both disability and queerness stand in contrast to so-called normative identities. Drawing on Judith Butler's theory on gender performativity, Robert McRuer argues that disability is a product of 'compulsory able-bodiedness', a system that appears to be 'thoroughly interwoven' with compulsory heterosexuality that produces queerness. See Robert McRuer, *Crip Theory: Cultural Signs of Queerness and Disability* (New York and London: New York University Press, 2006), 2.

97. Warren-Crow, 'Acquired Community', 52.

98. Ibid.

99. Ibid., 53.

100. Quoted in Tilley, *Leigh Bowery: The Life and Times of an Icon*, 112.

101. Susan Stewart, *On Longing: Narratives of the Miniature, the Gigantic, the Souvenir, the Collection* (Durham and London: Duke University Press, 1993), 109.

networks during the AIDS crisis in the 1980s.⁹³ She mentions that spots, which Bowery used extensively as a pattern on his costumes and make-up and are historically linked to disease and infection, can be viewed as the aestheticization of Kaposi's sarcoma (a skin cancer closely associated with HIV/AIDS) and as a means, therefore, for 'hypervisibility' of the sick queer body.⁹⁴ Confined at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery but gloriously self-assured, Bowery assumes the embodiment of an abject subject with its entire 'excessiveness, artificiality, and promiscuity' manifest as a form of narcissism, and being emblematic of the main queer network, namely dance clubs and subcultural nightlife more broadly. His voluntary glamorous enfreakment, which, however, could be translated as a metaphor for the marginalization and stigmatization of HIV-positive individuals, unsettles common assumptions surrounding the failing queer body and its inevitable death due to a promiscuous lifestyle.⁹⁵

Looking at Bowery both as a narcissist and as HIV-positive suggests a generative comparison with disabled performers.⁹⁶ The video *Leigh Bowery* by The Disabled Avant-Garde (artists Aaron Williamson and Katherine Araniello) is 'one of the most unusual tributes' to Bowery, Warren-Crow observes.⁹⁷ The short video, which features the duo attired similarly to Bowery's various looks, watching his performance at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery on a TV screen and imitating some of his movements, 'makes a clear, queer connection between two [...] artists who identify as disability activists and Bowery [...] who claimed not to identify'.⁹⁸ Through his preoccupation with the freakish and by 'aestheticizing and re-materializing the stigma' with the 'spot' aesthetic, Bowery indicates that 'the marks affecting both queers and people with disabilities are not stable and natural but mobile and cultural'.⁹⁹ Ditching the natural for the sake of the artificial, he allowed through his performed freakery the emergence of endless possibilities of becoming and questioned the alleged normative physical body. As Bowery stated in an interview at *The Sunday Times* magazine, he liked to think that he 'reform[ed] rather than deform[ed] the body'.¹⁰⁰

Bowery's living installation at the Anthony d'Offay Gallery is a glorification of his self-induced freakishness, an imperative aspect of his performative costuming and an aftereffect of the early New Romantic scene. Distant from the blatantly confrontational quality of the performances that actively engage with a disability, his restaging of freak as live art within a contemporary context can still be viewed as a critique of the oppressive apparatus of normativity. By enacting the nightclub freak as spectacle in an exaggerated and self-absorbed manner, Bowery vividly illustrates the objectification of the unusually-looking subject and, most importantly, highlights the cultural and social constructiveness of freak signifying splendidly Susan Stewart's claim that the assumed 'freak of nature' is instead a 'freak of culture'.¹⁰¹